



“I’m Donna. I know everything.”

— DONNA PAULSEN, SUITS

BUILD YOUR OWN DONNA

A 90 minute workshop for executives who are done reading email.

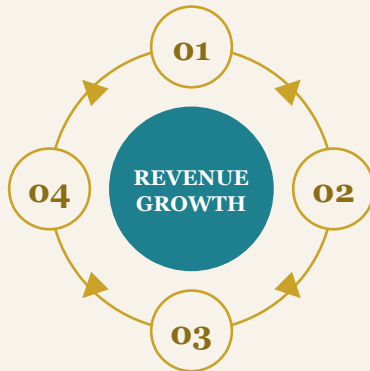
DENISE GOSNELL, PH.D. · 2:40 TO 4:10



WHERE WE JUST WERE, AND WHERE WE ARE GOING

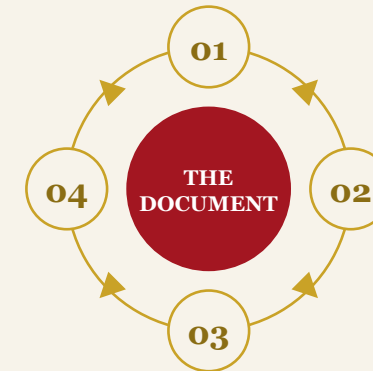
Same coin. You just saw one side.

1:30 · THE STRATEGY FLYWHEEL



BOOKINGS · DATA · PERSONAL TRIPS · BOOKINGS

2:40 · THE EXECUTION FLYWHEEL



DOCUMENT · TEST · REVISE · OPERATE

◆
ONE COIN

SigCompass showed you where we are driving. This hour asks the same question a second time: how does knowledge move across a business? And it answers the promise we left open at 2:20, something that runs without anyone remembering to run it.

AI only speeds up your current processes by 10x.

10x more confusion. ♦ 10x more alignment.

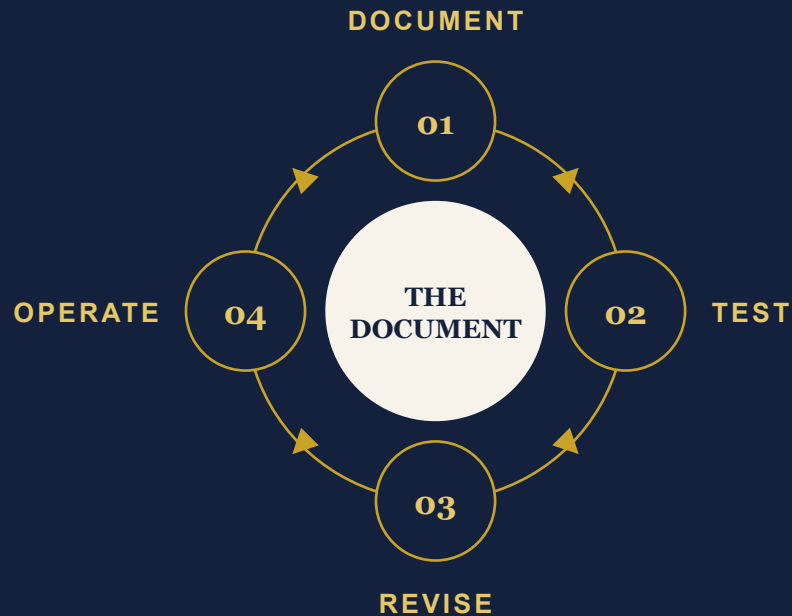
Today is an argument for the second one.

We are all learning to play doubles, and the balls just started coming a lot faster. The answer is not more creative plays. It is more basic ones. Emails. Numbers. Percentages. Knowing the same simple things at the same time, and acting on them together.

Reading the cockpit together is a fundamental. Bounce pass. Score. Then we get fancy.

HOW A NINE-FIGURE BUSINESS LINE ACTUALLY RUNS

Amazon won on documents.



01 DOCUMENT

One person writes down what they know. Prose, not slides.

02 TEST

The room reads in silence and attacks the document, not the person.

03 REVISE

It absorbs the debate. The writing is the thinking.

04 OPERATE

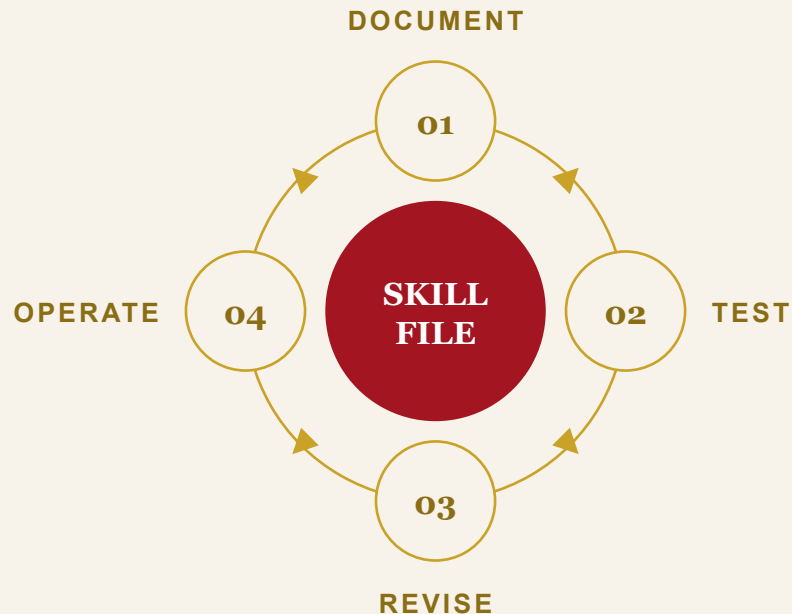
Teams work backwards from it. Every metric has a named owner.

Bezos took PowerPoint out of the S-Team room. What replaced it was not a better meeting. It was an artifact that outlives the meeting.

Bryar & Carr, Working Backwards (2021). Nonaka & Takeuchi, The Knowledge-Creating Company (1995).

WHAT CHANGED

The artifact is now a skill file.



01 DOCUMENT

You write the file. Your people, your rules, your voice.

02 TEST

The agent reads it. It cannot be charmed and it does not skim.

03 REVISE

You edit the file. Not the model. The file.

04 OPERATE

You put it on a schedule. It runs at 4:30 without you.

Same four steps. The reader used to be a room. Now it is an agent. That is the entire difference, and it is the whole workshop.

AI does not fix a broken process. It runs it faster.

88%

of organizations use AI somewhere.

~6%

see real profit impact from it.

21%

have redesigned a single workflow.

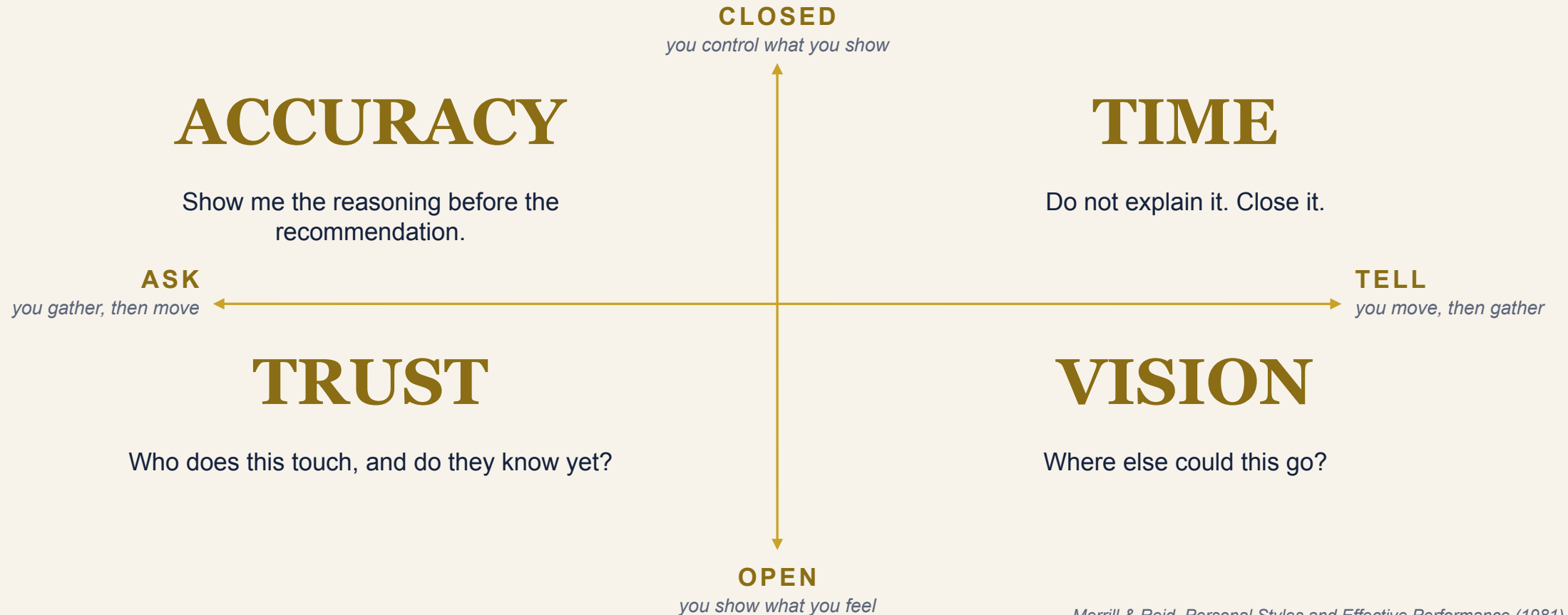
Of roughly 25 things McKinsey tested, one predicts profit impact above all others: fundamentally redesigning the workflow.

A vague document used to waste a meeting. A vague document now runs ten thousand times a day.

McKinsey, *The State of AI* (2025).

BEFORE YOU WRITE ANYTHING, KNOW WHO IS HOLDING THE PEN

Four kinds of executive.



SO HERE IS YOUR ASSIGNMENT

Four ways to spend the next hour.

CLOSED

ACCURACY

Your lens: Show me the reasoning before the recommendation.

Your job today: Hunt the non-determinism. Scaled wrong knowledge is what slows a business down.

You leave with: Governance that builds repeatability.

ASK ←

TRUST

Your lens: Who does this touch, and do they know yet?

Your job today: Decide where human relationships are best served by technology, not replaced by it.

You leave with: Where AI helps people flourish, not fry them.

TIME

Your lens: You want it running before I finish the sentence.

Your job today: Experience this as the job description you are about to hire for.

You leave with: How you delegate and invest in this workflow.

→ TELL

VISION

Your lens: Where else could this go?

Your job today: Today is email plus plain English. See the invisible digital headquarters behind it.

You leave with: The first worlds you can build from here.

OPEN

HOUSE RULES

Five of them.

- 1** She never sends. Drafts only. You are the send button.
- 2** She never deletes. Nothing we do today is destructive.
- 3** We move together. Every step ends at a checkpoint.
- 4** Copy buttons everywhere. Nobody types more than a sentence.
- 5** No question is too small. Stuck for 60 seconds, hand up.

If anything I just said did not compute, perfect. You are exactly who this is for.

Three steps. Forty-five minutes.

01

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

One desk for everything. Connect your email and calendar, and she drafts her first reply.

DOCUMENT · TEST

02

THE TRIAGE DESK

You brief her once. Red, yellow, gray. Your people, your priorities, your voice.

REVISE

03

DONNA, FULL TIME

Her playbook becomes a skill she keeps, and she takes the 4:30 evening shift.

OPERATE

Every step is one station of the flywheel. You write a document, you test it, and you put it on the clock.

STEP ONE

First impressions.

Give her a desk, connect your inbox, and watch her read it.

Create her project, then connect.

THE SETUP

- ◆ Projects, then New project. Name it Donna.
- ◆ Settings, then Connectors.
- ◆ Connect Gmail, Calendar, and Drive. All three, now.

Outlook: Microsoft 365 covers mail, calendar, and files in one.

STUCK CONNECTING? PASTE THIS

Walk me through connecting my work email and calendar to Claude, step by step, naming the exact buttons on my screen.

PROMPT 1 · THE QUESTION

What landed in my inbox in the last 24 hours that actually needs ME? Top 5, one line each.

PROMPT 2 · THE FIRST DRAFT

Draft a reply to #1. Under 100 words, warm but decisive. Save it as a draft in my email so I can review it there. Do not send it.

◆

A draft you didn't write is waiting in your drafts folder.

The interview is over. She's hired. Now we train her.



STEP TWO

The triage desk.

Teach her your rules once, and never explain them again.



This is the document.

PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS · FILL 4 BLANKS

You are Donna, my inbox triage assistant.

When I say "triage my inbox":

1. Review my inbox (default: the last 24 hours).
2. Sort every thread into three buckets:
RED, NEEDS ME - my VIPs, plus my #1 project:
[ADD 3-5 NAMES + EMAILS] . [ADD YOUR #1 DEAL]
YELLOW, DELEGATE - work my team owns:
[ADD 1-3 DELEGATES + LANES, e.g. "Sam: billing"]
GRAY, IGNORE - newsletters, cold outreach, noise.
3. Show me ONE table: sender, subject, bucket, why, next move.
4. Draft replies for REDs (my voice: [ADD 3 WORDS]) and handoff notes for YELLOWs. Save to Drafts. Never send anything. Never delete. Drafts only.

THE FOUR BLANKS

◆ Your always-red list

the people who jump every queue

◆ Your #1 deal

the one project that is always urgent

◆ Your delegates and lanes

one to three people, and what each owns

◆ Your voice, in 3 words

warm, brief, decisive is a fine start



You get one table instead of an inbox.

THE ENTIRE DAILY RITUAL, FROM NOW ON

Triage my inbox.

Chat is a conversation. A project is a standing arrangement.

STEP THREE

Donna, full time.

The document leaves your hands and goes on the clock.

She writes her own playbook.

PASTE INSIDE YOUR DONNA PROJECT

Turn this project's triage instructions into a reusable skill file called donna-replies. Use everything you already know from this project: my VIPs, my delegates, my voice, my rules. Include the line "Never send. Never delete. No exceptions." Then give me the finished SKILL.md as a file I can download.

◆ You should see donna-replies in your Cowork skills list before anyone touches scheduled tasks.

THEN THE HANDOFF

- 1 She writes the file.
- 2 You download it. The file card has a download arrow.
- 3 Cowork, then Skills, then Add skill, then upload it.



She never sends. Ever.

Every reply and every handoff note lands in your drafts and waits for your say-so. She never deletes anything either.

Written into the skill itself: "Never send. Never delete. No exceptions."



Give her the 4:30 shift.

COWORK · SCHEDULED TASKS · NEW TASK

Every weekday at 4:30 PM, use my donna-replies skill:

1. Triage today's inbox; save red replies and yellow handoffs to my Drafts.
2. Write my Daily Briefing doc, "Daily Briefing: [today's date]":
 - . the 5 things that need ME
 - . the replies you drafted
 - . what you ignored and why
 - . my first meeting tomorrow
3. Save it to my Drive in a folder "Donna Briefings".
4. Create a calendar event today 4:55-5:00 PM, "Briefing with Donna", doc link in the description, reminder 1 minute before.

Also: do a dry run for today RIGHT NOW.

4:30

she works

4:54

you are notified

4:55

a five-minute read

GMAIL VS OUTLOOK

- ◆ Google Calendar sends a true email reminder one minute before.
- ◆ Microsoft 365 sends a calendar notification. Both get the 4:54 nudge.

4:54 PM

Her first briefing arrives before you leave the room.

The trick: Claude never emails you. Your calendar does. The briefing lands from a sender you already trust.

Four stations lit. That is the flywheel, running on your inbox.

This was never about email.

You automated a workflow today by writing plain English. Rules became a project, the project became a skill, and the skill got a schedule.

Email was the rehearsal. The same flywheel runs any workflow you can describe in words.

How did your quadrant experience that?

ACCURACY

Where did you find the non-determinism, and what would you make it prove before you trusted it?

TIME

What is the job description you just watched someone need, and who is it?

TRUST

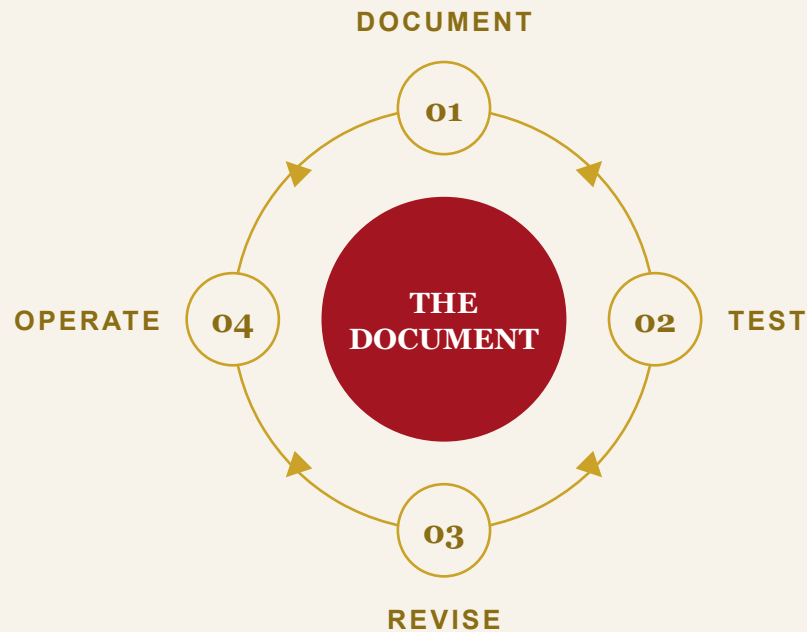
Where did this get close to a relationship you would not hand over?

VISION

What was the second thing on your list before I finished the first step?

Every one of you sat through a different workshop. That is the point.

Where does this flywheel turn next?



- ◆ **DOCUMENT:** What do you re-explain to somebody every single week?
- ◆ **TEST:** What arrives daily that somebody else summarizes for you?
- ◆ **REVISE:** Which decision waits on you only because the information is scattered?
- ◆ **OPERATE:** What would you want running at 4:30 tomorrow without you?

Answer any one of these out loud and you have just specified your next agent.

Four assignments. One per quadrant.

TIME *closed · tell*

Own the delegation.

What priority is AI workflow for you, your S-team, and your company? Appoint a lead. Set a timeline.

ACCURACY *closed · ask*

Harden the ground.

Name the data, systems, and processes that must be trustworthy before we scale decisions on top of them.

TRUST *open · ask*

Write the design principles.

How does this help you, your leadership team, and your people flourish as human beings? You hold the adoption criteria.

VISION *open · tell*

Draw the flywheels.

Three to five years out: how is the business run, what is automated, what reaches the S-team, the O-team, directors, managers?

AND HERE IS THE USEFUL PART: each of these four creates tension for the other three. That tension is your requirement set, your governance, and your strategic direction. You need all four in the room.



*“If you were ever lucky enough to have me, you
wouldn’t want to share.”*

— DONNA PAULSEN, SUITS

Yours starts tomorrow at 4:54.

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